Castro. Certainly, in May 1962 the Attorney-General was briefed on the Mafia connection. There is no record that the senior legal officer of the United States government pursued legal action against any official involved. Indeed, a new phase began of using the criminal underworld to help murder the Cuban Prime Minister.

Disclosures to the Senate investigations (augmented by later declassification of incriminating documentation) provide historians with insights into who knew what and when. Had allegations of this kind been made by investigative journalists or foreign governments, they would have been dismissed by US authorities as (what is now called) 'fake news' or disinformation from Moscow or Havana. The operation weakened the moral authority of the United States and gave succour to those who inhabit the world of conspiracy theory.

The Bay of Pigs was a humiliation for Kennedy. Publicly, he accepted responsibility. He told the press corps: 'There's an old saying that victory has a hundred fathers and defeat is an orphan,' and declared, 'I am the responsible officer of this government.'[70] His private views on the paternity of Operation Zapata were rather different – he inveighed against the 'sons o' bitches' in the Joint Chiefs of Staff and the 'bastards' in CIA.[71] The agency's post-mortem on the operation, conducted by its Inspector General, Lyman Kirkpatrick, produced a 170-page indictment of Operation Zapata.[72] The report was controversial within Langley. Allen Dulles described it as a 'hatchet job.'[73] A CIA internal history of the Bay of Pigs was later critical of Kirkpatrick's motives (resentment at his career progression) and methods (key officials, including Dulles and Bissell, were never questioned).[74] In any case, by the time the CIA Inspector-General delivered his report in November 1961, the President had decided a change of leadership at the agency was necessary.

Both Allen Dulles and Richard Bissell were required to resign, though not before dignified periods elapsed (and before both received the National Security Medal). Dulles left in September 1961 and Bissell in February 1962 (having served as acting-DCI after Dulles departed). Kennedy told Bissell, 'If this were a parliamentary government I would have to resign and you, a civil servant, would stay on. But being the system of government it